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He has been with Amazon since 1999, long enough to have watched the company evolve from an online bookstore into an everything store, a global technology conglomerate, and a major long-term investor in India. So, when Amazon recently announced a \$35-billion investment in the country, it made sense to speak with Amit Agarwal, Senior Vice President for Emerging Markets at Amazon, and one of the executives closest to that growth story.

In a conversation with BT, Agarwal spoke about what the announcement signals. He also reflected on his years at Amazon and what he took away from working closely with founder Jeff Bezos as his technical advisor in 2007—especially the focus on customer obsession, innovation and thinking big.

That thinking, Agarwal confirms, is also reflected in the way Amazon runs meetings. It is true, he explains, that meetings often begin with everyone reading a memo first. For every meeting, there is an owner who brings a six-page narrative and a set of anticipated questions from the reader with upfront answers. The six-page limit is deliberate: it forces clarity and crisp thinking, unlike presentations or long write-ups where it is easy to drift. Edited excerpts:

SZ: Take us through the details of the investment. Why India and why now?

A: Let me give you a little bit of perspective. We started here in 2003, and that was our first development centre, essentially software development and product

talent building capabilities for our global business. In 2013, we launched Amazon.in. We have also launched Amazon Web Services, Prime Video, MX Player. We have many different businesses that are all thriving and scaling well in the country. And back in 2020—when Jeff Bezos was here—he boldly declared how the 21st century is likely to be India's century. And we made three pledges at that point in time. We pledged to digitise 10 million small and medium-sized businesses, enable \$20 billion in exports, and support two million jobs. We have delivered on those pledges ahead of time. Between 2010 and 2024, we invested \$40 billion, making Amazon the largest foreign investor in India, the largest enabler of exports, and one of the largest creators of jobs in the country. Now, as we look forward to the next five years, we estimate we are going to invest an additional \$35 billion by 2030. Based on the momentum we are seeing in exports, we aim to enable \$80 billion in cumulative exports by 2030 and support 3.8 million jobs. On the digitisation front, we are leaning into AI, which is probably the biggest disruption of our lifetime. We want to empower four million government school kids with AI literacy and training. All in all, we are very proud that Amazon is the largest foreign investor in the country and the largest enabler of exports and jobs.

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SZ: In today's “10-minute delivery” era, it may be important to note that you introduced next-day delivery in India around 2013. Can you elaborate on that?

A: We have always been focused on speed. And to that end we are probably the only unique online place in India where customers can get 10,000 items in 10 minutes, 100,000 items in hours, 1 million items the same day and next day—and all this with free delivery for Prime members. This is probably the best deal on earth! I do not feel very surprised that we find our customers loving convenience,